

STOP WASTING CDs

Install Linux Straight from an ISO

You download the brand new Debian 5 (when it's released) after waiting for so many months, and discover you don't have a single blank DVD to burn the ISO image! Why worry, when there's a simple way out!



*G*NU/Linux comes in many different flavours, apart from the fact that each individual distro has a new release almost every six months, if not less. I have a habit of trying out every new version the moment it comes out, and I'm sure many of you do too.

Now, let's assume you have downloaded a new version of a distro and are in the mood to try it out right away. It's past midnight and you realise that you've run out of blank CDs/DVDs. So you will have to wait till the morning when the shops open, to be able to burn the distro image in order to install it. I'm sure a lot of us often face this problem. In this article I'll share a simple trick by which you can install the new distro without burning it to a CD/DVD. The only requirement

is that you should have a pre-installed GNU/Linux system—which you already have, otherwise where did you download the ISO image from?

All Linux installers use two files to boot a computer: a kernel and an initial root filesystem -- also known as the RAM disk or *initrd* image. This *initrd* image contains a set of executables and drivers that are needed to mount the real root filesystem. When the real root filesystem mounts, the *initrd* is unmounted and its memory is freed. These two files are named differently in different distros—refer to Table 1 for their names.

The first thing you need to do is place the ISO image(s) inside a directory. Some installers are not able to read the ISO images if they are placed inside a directory. So, just to be on the safe side, place them in the root of the file system. The partition on the hard disk holding the ISO files must be formatted with the ext2, ext3 or vfat file system.

In our example, let's go ahead and do it with an old Fedora 9 ISO image. Follow these steps to begin with:

```
# mkdir /fedora
```